As to the need for the Caliph to hold such temporal power, there were even those among Muslims who disputed this, and did not recognise the Caliph as their leader, including the Arabs.[134] As Dobbs argued when the Afghan delegation at Mussoorie brought up the issue, 'At one time there were three Khilafats in simultaneous and rival existence...This shows how very careful you should be in laying down the law and making all sorts of statements about the Khilafat.'[135] In fact, in the opinion of some in the British government, the Caliph issue was simply an excuse for anti-British propagandists, 'who have in past times betrayed no great interest in the fortunes of the Ottoman Empire'.[136] Indeed, with Gandhi lending his support to the Caliphate movement, Crowe argued that this was 'further evidence that the religious side of the movement is purely fictitious. It is a nationalist and anti-British movement of all extremist parties'.[137]

Whether the Caliphate agitators were genuinely moved by religion or not was somewhat irrelevant to the matter at hand.[138] The Nizam of Hyderabad summarised the issue to Chelmsford:

The Headship of Islam has been a polemic for years during which it did not rise beyond academic interest, but the present situation has given it a turn which defies sober reasoning and theological examination. Popular psychology is not necessarily logical or answerable to historical verities, and in practical politics what counts is fact and not theories.[139]

In effect, the Caliphate issue was a convenient rallying point for all the discontent that was accumulating in India and South Asia at large in the post-war period.[140] Muslims who had once shown complete loyalty to the Raj now felt 'thoroughly ashamed of themselves' for having fought in the British Indian army against their co-religionists; 'They had joined the Christian powers to fight against Muslims and had not received any reward for that, neither any degree of self-government for India nor any particular advancement in the status of the Muslim community.'[141] Kemal Ataturk was astute in exploiting such feelings of Muslim solidarity and the